

Raising the Iron Curtain

Following the defeat of Nazi Germany, tension between the superpowers split Europe into a communist “East” and a capitalist “West.” Gorbachev’s repeal of the “Brezhnev Doctrine” opened the floodgates for popular demands for reform, leading to the dismantling of the Iron Curtain across Eastern Europe.

It was the former British prime minister Winston Churchill (see pp.392–93) who likened the division of East and West in 1946 to “an iron curtain descended across the Continent.” Inhabitants of Eastern Europe were prohibited from crossing into the West, and most people knew little about the way of life on the other side. The first indications that the curtain might rise came in 1985, when Mikhail Gorbachev was appointed General Secretary of the Soviet Communist Party. Gorbachev proposed to set Russia on a new course (see pp.446–47), but his vision required a transformation in East–West relations.

In 1983, US president Ronald Reagan’s decision to fund a space-based missile defense system, known as Star Wars, suggested a continuing escalation of the arms race (the competitive stockpiling of more and more powerful weapons), but in 1986 Gorbachev stunned the international community with a call to eliminate all nuclear weapons by the year 2000. This move led to the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces (INF) Treaty in 1987—a first step toward dismantling the superpowers’ massive nuclear arsenals.

Gorbachev’s role in reversing the arms race won him worldwide acclaim. In 1988 he went on to push through his most radical reform of Soviet foreign policy: the abandonment of the “Brezhnev Doctrine,” which prohibited Eastern Bloc (see BEFORE) and other satellite countries from reforming their political systems. This doctrine had led to military intervention in Czechoslovakia in 1968 and Afghanistan in 1979 (see pp.444–45).

A wave of popular protest developed within the Eastern Bloc countries, calling for an end to communist rule. By 1989, East Germany was faced with a rapidly depleting workforce as thousands of citizens decamped to West Germany via Hungary and Czechoslovakia. In November the government agreed to open its borders with West Germany, and

citizens poured across the border to greet their former countrymen. In 1990 politicians on both sides agreed to the reunification of Germany.

Solidarity wins out

In Poland, popular desire for change led to the emergence of the Solidarity Trade Union Movement in the early 1980s. The movement demanded workers’ rights and the freedom to practice Catholicism—banned

BEFORE

As the Cold War intensified, the Soviet Union acted to increase its control of political policy in the satellite Eastern Bloc states.

EUROPE DIVIDED

After World War II, **new national boundaries were created and countries divided** as the victorious Allies determined the future shape of Europe. Stalin ensured that the Soviet Union incorporated eastern Poland and the Baltic States. **Germany and its capital, Berlin, were divided** into Eastern and Western sectors << 426–27.

COMMUNISM IN EASTERN EUROPE

By 1949, communist regimes had been established in Albania, Romania, Hungary, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia, Poland, and East Germany. Although nominally independent, these nations were **dominated by the Soviet Union**. Collectively known as the **Eastern Bloc**, these Soviet satellite states were required to **mirror Soviet political structures** and to join the Soviet military alliance, the **Warsaw Pact**.

SOVIET IMPERIALISM

The Soviet Union did not tolerate rebellion or divergence from its party line. In 1953, Soviet troops suppressed riots and a general strike in East Germany, and when, in 1956, discontent with the Hungarian communist government led to nationwide revolt, the uprising was crushed with massive military force. In 1968, during a period known as the “**Prague Spring**,” Czechoslovakia introduced liberalizing measures. Forces from the Warsaw Pact invaded and reestablished communist party discipline.

Casting off communism

With the threat of Soviet interference removed, communist governments found it difficult to keep control.



Romanian revolution

People shelter behind army tanks in Bucharest during Eastern Europe’s most violent transition to democracy. More than 1,000 Romanians were killed in clashes between demonstrators and security forces.

Turbulent times

A revolutionary holds a Romanian flag, the communist symbol defiantly torn from its center, and looks down on Palace Square in Bucharest, days before the overthrow of Ceaușescu’s regime in December 1989.



A new Hungary

Citizens wave pro-democracy banners as the Republic of Hungary is proclaimed on October 23, 1989—the anniversary of the 1956 Hungarian Uprising against the Soviet Union.